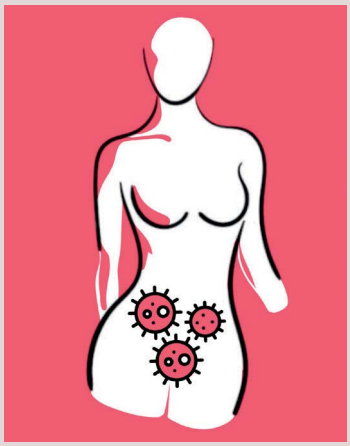
studies estimate costs to be anywhere between Rs 1.6 lakh and Rs 4 lakh. The expenses multiply as the cancer worsens, with treatment often continuing for life to avoid relapse. And all that with no guarantee for cure. "In the late stage of cervical cancer, cure is not even possible and the success is less, I would say, almost half of that in breast cancer," says Dr Nayyar. Add to this the myriad side-effects of drugs and radiation, and you have a situation made tragic not least by the simple fact that it could have been avoided. "There is extensive use of radiation, and that has its own side-effects.... Even if the normal surrounding tissues are shielded, a small amount of radiation can impact the rectum and bladder and women often have urinary side-effects, diarrhoea and pain after treatment," Dr Nayyar adds.

Over the past few years, oncologists have noted a rise in cases in urban areas as well as among women aged 40-55 years, which was uncommon before. "I would say people having multiple partners but not having enough awareness or not complying with proper sexual hygiene and protection, has led to the rise," says Dr Reshma Puranik, a Pune-based oncologist.

WHAT CAUSES CERVICAL CANCER

- Almost all cervical cancers are caused by the human papillomavirus (HPV), which can be passed from one person to another during sexual activity. The virus colonises the cervix, where it causes some precancerous mutations that may then lead to a cancerous tumour





SIGNS TO WATCH OUT FOR

- Bleeding between periods, vaginal discharge, post-coital bleeding or pain, lower abdominal pain

WHY EARLY DIAGNOSIS IS CRUCIAL



- Once the cancer progresses, it can cause obstruction of kidneys, recurrent urinary tract infections, distended abdomen, and infect other organs with a tumour
- At the earliest stage, chemotherapy can be avoided and a surgery to remove the tumour, uterus and cervix may be required
- Experts recommend an annual pap smear for those above the age of 35

VICTIM OF MISNFORMATION

Lack of awareness is the primary reason for poor vaccination rates. The LNJP doctor says that in the past four months, he has tried to advise many young girls and parents to get the shot. Out of around 50 such people, only three agreed. The rest, he says, had excuses that ranged from "But my daughter will have sex only after marriage, how can she get an STI?" to "She is too young to take a vaccine".

"There is poor awareness on adult vaccines, more so for a sexually transmitted virus like HPV. People also fall victim to social media information," says Dr Ashok Vaid, chairman of oncology at Medanta, Gurugram. Fear of side-effects was what kept 29-year-old Aryushi Arora, a Pune-based art teacher, from taking the vaccine. "I had read it can cause dryness in your vagina. But then, when I finally went for a pap smear, the doctor told me this was untrue. I went ahead and took the vaccine," she says.

Experts agree that the immediate need is to educate people about both the disease and its prevention, especially given the immense promise the vaccine holds in reducing India's cervical cancer burden. "We need to assure people that there are virtually no side-effects of the vaccine. At best, a mild bodyache. Allergy to this vaccine is extremely rare and it is perfectly safe for young girls to take. I sometimes attend vaccination camps and feel awareness and outreach will help tackle hesitancy," says Dr Puranik. Screening also needs to be expanded massively to detect the cancer early. "The biggest problem is late-stage diagnosis; screening for those above 35 has to be increased," says Dr N.K. Arora, chairman of the National Technical Advisory Group on Immunisation.

Countries like Bhutan, the Maldives, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Thailand have already introduced nationwide vaccination programmes to prevent cervical cancer. Given the success of India's Covid vaccination drive—the largest in the world—experts now hope that the government will come up with a similar programme for cervical cancer. The country does, after all, have a robust vaccination framework in place already. All that's needed is intent. ■